ONE-OFF SHIURIM

Why the Seventh Day? Shabbat and the Cycle of Time

Derech Hashem 4:7:1-2

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 4, Chapter 7, paragraphs 1-2 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 31 March 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

A new category: periodic misvot (paragraph 1)

Having finished the order of the day, the class moved to Chapter 7, "Avodah Zemanit", periodic service. These are misvot that certainly come, but not every day. The Rabbi placed it in the structure of Part 4: constant misvot (fear and love of God), daily misvot (sisit, tefillin, Shema, Amidah) and now this category.

The Ramhal lists them all:

- Resting on Shabbat, including the 39 melakhot, and the holiness of Shabbat, meaning its positive side, such as wearing special clothes.
- No work on the tenth of Tishri, and its five afflictions.
- Resting on Yom Tov, apart from melakhah for food, and its holiness and festive joy.
- Eating massah and avoiding hames on Pesah.
- Living in the sukkah and taking the lulav on Sukkot.

The Ramhal says there is nothing outside this list. A participant suggested the blessing on blossoming trees, and another Birkat HaLevanah. The Rabbi explained that these belong to the circumstantial category: you do not have to go and look at the trees or the moon; if you see them, you bless. "You have to eat massah, you have to shake your lulav. It's different."

Holiness in a mundane world (paragraph 2)

As learned in Part 2, the world is weighted to the mundane rather than the holy, which is why a person who stays static in it goes down. So creatures need extra sanctification from time to time, so as not to be swallowed by darkness. God, with exact precision, set how much mundanity there should be and how much holiness is needed, in quality and quantity, in place and in time.

In place: the Land of Israel, Jerusalem, the graves of the righteous, the Kotel, and here, the synagogue. In time: most days are mundane and some are holy, and the holy days themselves

have levels. Yom Kippur is holier than Yom Tov, Yom Tov than Rosh Hodesh, Rosh Hodesh than Hanukkah.

The Rabbi found this striking. We are used to holiness in tangible things, a Sefer Torah or a mezuzah, and even in places, which we can feel. "Time, what's time? You can't feel anything." Yet time too has holiness.

The cycle of seven

God decided that days should repeat in a constant cycle, and the cycle is seven, because all of existence was created in seven days and included in that number. "It's fascinating that throughout the world everyone accepts the concept of a seven-day week."

Not only days, but years. As learned in Part 1, there are six thousand years followed by a thousand years of rest, like Shabbat. And God wanted the end of each cycle always to be holy: Shabbat at the end of the week, the seventh millennium, Shemittah in the seventh year, and Yovel in the fiftieth year, after seven cycles of seven.

Why at the end? Because the end elevates everything before it. Although most of the days are mundane and only one seventh is holy, that seventh is the seal of the cycle, and so it rectifies the whole cycle and all a person's days are elevated.

So Shabbat must be at the end of the week. "People say, if Shabbat is about resting, why can't I rest on a Sunday, or a Wednesday afternoon? You're missing the whole point." It is the last day that gives the elevation to the rest.

A gift for Israel

This is a great gift, given to Israel and not to the nations. The Gemara in Shabbat says that God told Moshe, "I have a good gift in My treasure house, and Shabbat is its name." So the halachah is that a non-Jew may not keep Shabbat, as we say in the Shabbat prayers: You did not give it to the nations.

The Rabbi raised the obvious question: non-Jews too should believe God created the world in six days and rested on the seventh, so why not celebrate Shabbat? The answer follows from the Ramhal: Shabbat is not only a celebration of creation; its main aspect is giving holiness to the rest of the time, and that was designated specifically for Israel, "a sign between Me and you."

Seven everywhere

The number seven keeps coming up: in cycles, in music, in Sheva Berakhot, the seven seas, the seven colours of the rainbow. The Kuzari says the whole world keeps a seven-day week because it is ingrained in existence.

The Maharal explains why the seventh day has no work. Everything physical has at most six sides, like a cube or a house. But to build a six-sided cupboard you need, most importantly, a centre point to build the sides around. The centre is nothing tangible, yet it gives the whole structure its framework. Shabbat is the same: nothing is done on it, but it gives the framework for the six days.

The Kabbalah has a related idea: the days before Shabbat build up toward it, with added levels of soul, and after Shabbat we come down through the following days, so that Shabbat stands in the middle of the week with everything else revolving around it.

Time or place?

Finally the Rabbi asked: which is greater, the holiness of place or of time? Place is easier for us to feel. But time is greater, and the proof is the Mishkan, the greatest holiness of place, whose building had to stop for Shabbat. "Zeman is always greater than makom."

Summary

- The periodic misvot are Shabbat, Yom Kippur, Yom Tov, massah and hames, sukkah and lulav; blessings on trees or the moon are circumstantial.
- Because the world is mostly mundane, God set exact measures of holiness in place and in time, with levels among the holy days.
- All existence came in seven, so time runs in cycles of seven, and the holy part comes at the end and elevates the whole cycle.
- Shabbat is a gift to Israel alone, because its essence is sanctifying the rest of time.
- The holiness of time is greater than that of place: building the Mishkan stopped for Shabbat.

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